

Nyctibius griseus

Common potoo



Location S. Central America, South America

Length 13–15 in (33–38 cm)
Weight 5–7 oz (150–200 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



One of 7 species of potoos found in Central and South America, the common potoo is a solitary bird that spends the day in trees, perching

upright, where it looks like a broken branch. It keeps its conspicuous yellow eyes shut to avoid detection by predators, but creases in the eyelids allow it to continue to watch for danger. This bird comes to life at night, darting from its perch to catch insects in the air. Birds form pairs for breeding, laying a single egg in a knothole or depression in a branch.



Phalaenoptilus nuttallii

Common poorwill



Location S. Canada, W. and C. USA, N. and C. Mexico

Length 7–8½ in (18–21 cm)
Weight 1½–2½ oz (30–60 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



The smallest North American nightjar, the common poorwill gets its name from the male's repetitive 2-note courtship call. It rests on the ground



during the day, the intricately patterned plumage providing effective camouflage in its often arid habitat. A night forager, the common poorwill swoops on flying insects from a perch. This bird conserves energy in winter by going into torpor—a hibernationlike state that is rarely found in birds.

Caprimulgus vexillarius

Pennat-winged nightjar



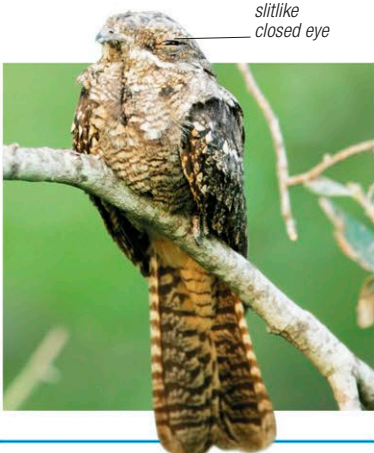
Location Central and N. America

Length 24–28 cm (10–11 in)
Weight 60–88 g (2–3 oz)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



Males' remarkable elongated, black-and-white "pennant" feathers in broad, black-tipped wings are striking, especially in high display flights. They are longest on older males, but become soiled and tattered as the bird roosts on the ground and feeds in flight

amongst scattered trees. The plumes are quickly shed after the breeding season, then being an unnecessary encumbrance. A typical nocturnal nightjar, it catches a great variety of insect prey in its wide gape.



Caprimulgus europaeus

European nightjar



Location Europe, W. to E. Asia, N.W., W., and S.E. Africa

Length 10–11 in (25–28 cm)
Weight 1¼–3½ oz (50–100 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



This bird is the only nightjar found in Northern Europe. It takes to the air after dark, catching flying insects on the wing. Males patrol their territories regularly, driving off intruders. During the breeding season, the male has a purring airborne song, which sounds like a piece of machinery. It also claps its wings, to display the white patches on the outer flight feathers. This bird does not build a nest; the eggs are laid directly on the ground, usually close to a tree or shrubs. The female rears the

CAMOUFLAGE



Like other nightjars, this species spends the day resting on the ground or on low branches. Its dull, mottled plumage renders it almost invisible on the ground among vegetation.

chicks initially, but after about 2 weeks she may leave them with the male and then lay a second clutch.

BROWN AND MOTTLED

The European nightjar has brown plumage, mottled with black and gray, and long, pointed wings.



Chordeiles minor

Common nighthawk



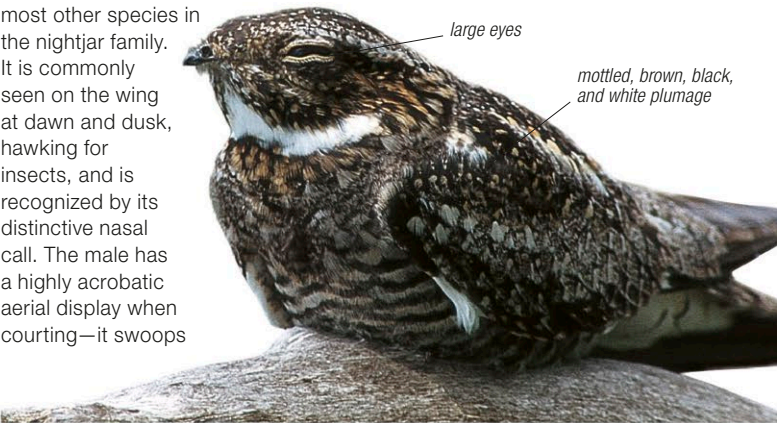
Location North, Central, and South America

Length 9–10 in (22–25 cm)
Weight 1½–3½ oz (45–100 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



A familiar summer visitor through much of North America, this nighthawk is more active by day than most other species in the nightjar family. It is commonly seen on the wing at dawn and dusk, hawking for insects, and is recognized by its distinctive nasal call. The male has a highly acrobatic aerial display when courting—it swoops

down low, making a hollow, booming sound with its wings, and almost colliding with its prospective partner. This bird nests and roosts in open places of all kinds. In some parts of the USA, it has taken to nesting on flat, gravel-covered roofs—a habitat that helps it to avoid some of its predators. The nest is often simply a shallow depression made in the ground, and the female alone cares for the eggs and chicks. When disturbed, the bird often flies up from the nest and settles nearby; occasionally, it will lunge at an intruder. After breeding, large flocks move south for the winter, traveling as far as Argentina.



Caprimulgus longipennis

Standard-winged nightjar



Location W., C., and E. Africa

Length 8½–10 in (21–25 cm)
Weight 2½–3¼ oz (60–90 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Male standard-winged nightjars are instantly recognizable in flight, because their breeding plumage includes 2 elongated wing feathers that can be up to 3 in (78 cm) long. They perform their aerial

courtship display at canopy level, often chased by females, but will also select a perch and show off their pennants there. More active during the day than some nightjars, the birds may forage in loose flocks or in pairs, when the female follows the male; they fly very high off the ground, catching insects on the wing.

